

Title

Feasibility and Community Uptake of HIV Prevention Services Delivered Through Barbershops in a High-Transmission Region of Uganda: Twelve-Month Results

Abstract

Identifying acceptable venues for HIV prevention engagement remains critical in high-burden settings. We randomized 12 barbershops in an urban district to deliver an integrated HIV prevention program and 6 control barbershops providing standard services. Approximately 250 men (mean age 34 years) were enrolled. The intervention achieved high feasibility: 94% of enrolled participants attended at least one educational session, 87% accepted self-testing kits, and 76% completed the offered peer-discussion group. Acceptability was strong, with 89% of participants rating the program as acceptable or highly acceptable. Among the intervention group, 68% initiated HIV testing during the study period compared with 42% in control barbershops (relative risk 1.62; 95% CI 1.15-2.28). Reported sexual risk behaviors showed greater reductions in the intervention arm (29% reduction vs. 8% in controls; $p=0.03$). Interest in long-acting preexposure prophylaxis increased in the intervention group (23% expressing interest vs. 12% in controls; $p<0.001$). Barbershops proved a feasible and acceptable venue for reaching men with HIV prevention services.